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Indira Gandhi's Assassination and the Anti-Sikh Pogrom

BBC AND AIR news broadcasts announced Bhindranwale's death in the morning on 7 June 1984. When I reached office that morning, there was unusual excitement and the young officers were huddled in small groups in some of the rooms. Obviously, they were discussing Operation Blue Star and the developments of the past two days. I realized that the Sikh employees of the Department would have been appalled by the ferocity of army action and the damage to the Akal Takht and the Golden Temple complex. I took it upon myself to call all four Sikh section officers (SOs) at the headquarters to my room. In the functioning of government offices in India, including at the R&AW, SOs as heads of various sections occupy a crucial position. Having worked in different capacities in different sections, they come to know most of the staff members personally.

All four section officers were old Intelligence Bureau (IB) hands who had come over to the R&AW when the department was created in 1968. All four had worked with me in the past, three of them very recently in two sensitive divisions, where they were still working, and one in the personnel branch when I joined the R&AW in 1972.

I told them that what had happened was unfortunate and should have been avoided at all costs. It was neither indicative of any Hindu-Sikh divide nor was it motivated out of any genuine threat perception about the demand for Khalistan. In fact, these issues were deliberately created by some senior Congress leaders for